

Desktop PCs

Winners for desktop PCs are **HP** and **ASSEMBLED PCs**

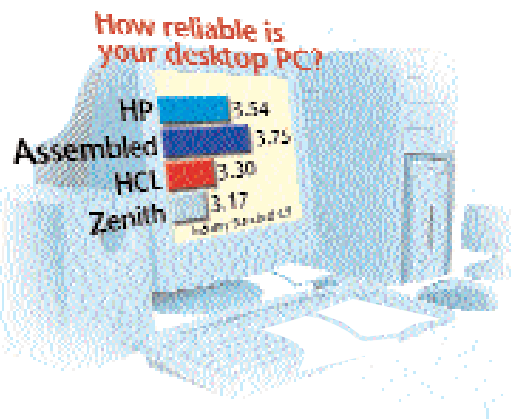


Assembled or branded? The supreme decision faced by anyone while purchasing a personal computer. It is as if the rest of our technological existence hinges on that one choice, and perhaps it does. For, the right path leads to product satisfaction, while the other is a rocky trail to electronic tribulation and support headache. Or is it? Our consumer survey certainly helped burst an old bubble that branded PCs are the way to go if you require technical support and after-sales product satisfaction. Surprisingly, the popular assembled PCs came up on top on both Reliability and Service Indices.

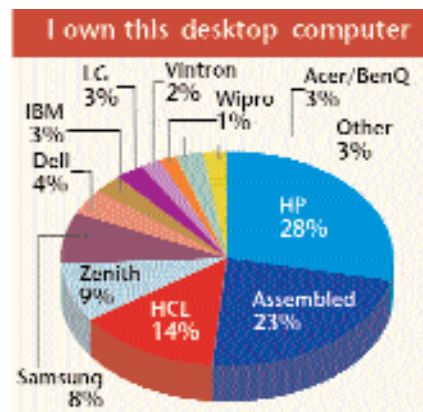
The desktop PCs category attracted

812 votes, a majority of which (237) went HP's way, closely followed by assembled computers tallying 194 mentions. Even if India has traditionally been a assembled-PC market, branded PCs have made significant inroads. HCL came in at no. 3 with 117, and Zenith was fourth with 75 votes. It must have been no mean task going against the peer-to-peer network that is the assembled market in India. The initial surprise of assembled units scoring on after-sales satisfaction can also be attributed to this peer-to-peer network of a friend, a colleague or a friend's colleague or a colleague's friend, who probably assembled your PC.

Indeed, the community of assemblers has roots in both grey markets, where they can source cheap parts (and offer a warranty to boot), and an engineering pool comprising recent graduates or diploma holders. The technical and the spares support is thus very much present. Add to this the fact that help is just a phone call away, plus the knowledge that the person on the other line will be receptive (you, or someone you know, probably knows the person), and you have all the makings of an excellent support group. Like Gaurav Lakshkar

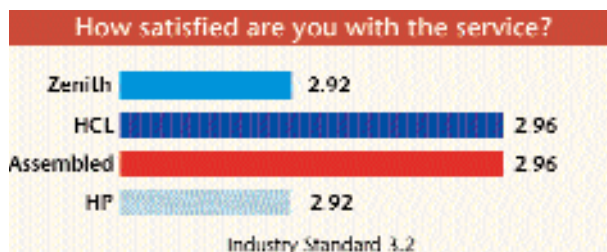


Zenith was the quickest in **providing solutions** to their problems; respondents were also the most satisfied with **technical personnel** of assembled computers



I would rather assemble my PC myself

V Vineeth Kumar, on assembled computers
Maharashtra



points out, "Whenever I take my problem to the vendor he always welcomes me even after the warranty period has expired. He always helps me in troubleshooting the problem."

Then there are the traditional reasons for opting for assembled computers: Be it flexibil-

ity, "Assembled PCs are flexible, and I can upgrade them easily; affordability, "I prefer assembled machines for their affordability; the customisable configuration and the "I would rather assemble my PC myself" bragging rights. Some respondents like Siddharth Deb Varman from Bangalore cautioned against using assembled systems. A student of management, Siddharth owns an assembled PC. He says, "Though assembled systems are cheaper and can be more personalised, the fly-by-night operators have become the real bad apples in the cart, and need to be rooted out." He is referring, of course, to assemblers who are here today and gone tomorrow. It is thus essential to do business with known persons, who have a certain amount of positive history and come with recommendations.

As for branded systems, HP is doing pretty good for itself. Its customers are satisfied by both its service: "It's a great

MOST RELIABLE DESKTOP COMPUTER: Assembled PCs RUNNER-UP: HP
MOST SATISFACTORY SERVICE: Tie between assembled and HCL PCs
RUNNER-UP: Tie between HCL and Zenith